



STILL IN PRINT Jyoti Bhatt in his studio at MSU Baroda, 1959; above, 'The Flight' (etching, 1978)

At 91, Jyoti Bhatt looks at showcases of his works as a means to hold on to a fast-fading memory; memory that's been slipping away like sand. The ongoing retrospective titled 'Jyoti Bhatt: Through the Line and the Lens...' by Latitude 28 in Delhi (on till May 25), and curated by artist Rekha Rodwittiya, puts on display the artist's complete collection from Bhavna Kakar's printmaking archive, featuring etchings, lithographs, serigraphs, photographs and personal writings, including diary entries and letters. It offers a unique insight into Bhatt's practice and philosophy. Over the years, his photographic documentation of India's living traditions forged a profound dialogue with his graphic prints.

In a career spanning over six decades, the artist's longstanding engagement with folk symbols and motifs, meticulously recorded in his notebooks, has helped build a distinctive visual vocabulary that marries local traditions with contemporary sensibilities. "Initially, I used photography to document my own work," Bhatt says, introspecting on his journey from sketching to picking up the camera. "Gradually, I began photographing the works of fellow artists and, eventually, the living traditions of rural and tribal India—something I continued for over 25 years. During that time, I more or less neglected painting and printmaking, returning to them only after retiring from teaching."

But ever since, Bhatt has remained unwavering in his commitment to pedagogy, championing printmaking not merely as an artistic pursuit but as a democratic medium, vital for mass dissemination and the nurturing of cultural literacy. As an intellectual, Bhatt occupies the intriguing position of not only being a conduit between modernist and contemporary art in India, but also being acutely unaware of his sway on the cultural landscape.

His unselfconsciousness allows him to have a disinterested view of things. In his graphic prints, Bhatt subtly integrated political critique to challenge institutions that opposed pluralism and liberal values. Considered ahead of his time, Bhatt experimented with text and art references, laying early foundations for post-modernist ideas that would take shape in Indian art years later.

And yet, the artist tends to shrug off the political import of his oeuvre. "I do not believe that works of art are bound to any single purpose or message," Bhatt says. "I have, from time to time, used certain images and symbols that might carry political implications. But, for me, the visual quality of the image has always been the primary concern, not the political or historical message it might convey."

In that vein, he clarifies how print and printmaking aren't the same. Printmaking is an artistic endeavour, unlike printing, a broader mechanical process of reproducing images. "Because prints are editioned and not physically unique in the way a painting or sculpture might be, some people don't appreciate them as original works of art. But each print carries the artist's intent and direct engagement with the medium," he says, adding that he has been just as excited about the digital avenues for art.

However, digital works are often not immediately recognised as original art. "Personally, I believe that the im-